

Nutrition for Older Adults

Meeting Changing Needs with Age

Nutritional needs change with age. Older adults often need fewer calories but more of certain nutrients, including protein, calcium, vitamin D, and vitamin B12. Reduced appetite, dental issues, and medication can affect food intake.

Key Nutrients of Concern

Protein helps maintain muscle mass, which tends to decline with age. Calcium and vitamin D support bone health. Vitamin B12 absorption decreases with age, and fiber intake often falls short, contributing to constipation.

Practical Eating Tips

Eating smaller, nutrient-dense meals more often can be easier than three large meals. Including protein at every meal, choosing whole grains, and staying hydrated are all useful. Social meals and gentle physical activity support appetite.

Suggested Items:

- Eggs, milk, paneer, and dal for protein
- Curd and milk for calcium
- Whole grains like oats, brown rice, and ragi
- Cooked vegetables and soft fruits for fiber
- Nuts and seeds (ground if needed) for healthy fats
- Fortified foods or supplements for vitamin B12 and D as advised

Reference Table

Nutrient	Why It Matters	Food Source
Protein	Maintains muscle	Eggs, dal, milk
Calcium	Bone health	Milk, curd, ragi
Vitamin D	Calcium absorption	Sunlight, fortified foods
B12	Nerve function	Eggs, fortified foods
Fiber	Digestion	Vegetables, oats

Conclusion

Regular, balanced meals and adequate hydration support healthy aging. Family and caregivers can help by sharing meals and offering a variety of foods.